

2026



THE RESPONSIBLE LEADERSHIP GAP REPORT

PUBLISHED JUNE 2026
N=25 GLOBAL LEADERS

PILOT STUDY · SECTORS: AI/ML, CONSULTING, ACADEMIA, SOCIAL IMPACT, BANKING GEOGRAPHIES: INDIA · EU · US · UK · AFRICA · APAC · LATIN AMERICA

What 25 Global Leaders
Revealed About AI, Ethics
and the Distance Between
Values and Action

KEY FINDINGS AT A GLANCE

70%+

cite speed as their biggest obstacle to responsible decision-making

87%

would retrain rather than make team members redundant in scenarios where AI adoption would otherwise eliminate roles

100%

100% link ethical values to long-term trust, even as institutions continue to reward speed

52%

navigate by inner clarity, even though organisations provide no infrastructure for it

AI is shifting the unit of decision from individual moments to system architecture

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THE COHERENCE CRISIS

Why This Matters Now

The coherence crisis and the AI leadership paradox.

Section 01

“

We are not in
a leadership crisis.
We are in a

LEADERSHIP COHERENCE CRISIS.

Leaders have values.
They lack the structures,
practices and community
to act on them
consistently.”

— SHEENA BHALLA · FOUNDER, MODULE XERO

We are living through a leadership coherence crisis. Not a leadership shortage as the world has no deficit of people in positions of authority. Not a value deficit. Our data shows that leaders across every sector and geography hold clear ethical commitments. The crisis is structural: the distance between what leaders believe and what their institutions make possible has become a measurable risk factor, not a philosophical concern.



THE AI LEADERSHIP PARADOX

Organisations are adopting AI faster than leaders are developing the human capacities needed to guide these technologies responsibly. The result is a systemic mismatch: technical capability is accelerating while ethical practice is stagnating.

The paradox runs deeper than speed. AI adds pace to existing work and fundamentally shifts the architecture of decision-making. When an algorithm makes ten thousand micro-decisions before a leader reviews one dashboard, responsible leadership can no longer operate only at the level of individual choices. It must operate at the level of systems design, governance architecture, and the values embedded in data and product decisions long before any human reviews them.

The leaders who participated in this study understand this intuitively. What they lack is not awareness — it is the structural conditions to act on what they know. Global trust in institutions, technology companies and leadership structures is rapidly eroding. The demand for transparency, care and connection has never been higher. Yet the practices that sustain these qualities are cultivated almost entirely outside the organisations these leaders lead. What is missing is not another framework. It is a coherent, embodied practice that leaders can sustain daily.

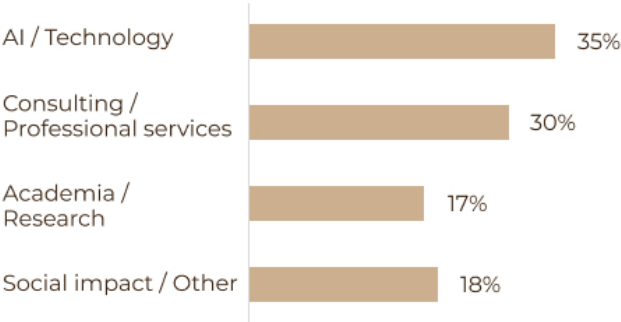
ABOUT THIS STUDY

Between December 2025 and January 2026, Module Xero conducted a pilot questionnaire with 25 global leaders. This report is the first instalment of a broader 500-leader research initiative.

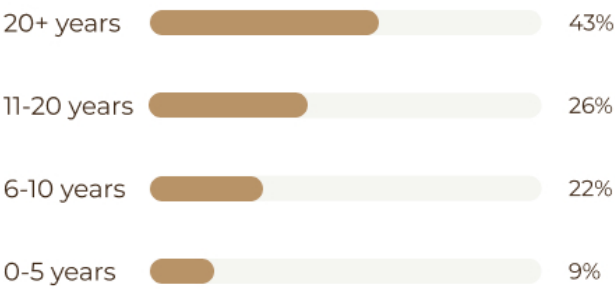
Respondents answered 12 questions spanning ethical decision-making, AI's impact on leadership, internal navigational signals, team management scenarios and personal grounding practices. Every response was read in full — not just coded — and the qualitative material is treated throughout as primary analytical data, not merely illustrative quotation.

RESPONDENT PROFILE

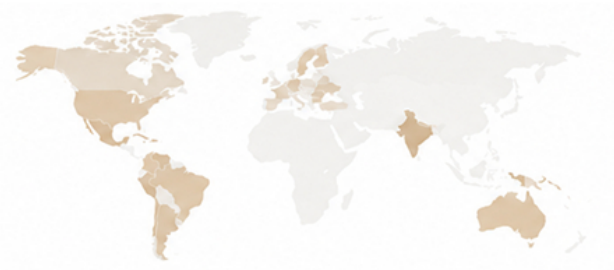
SECTOR



YEARS OF LEADERSHIP EXPERIENCE



GEOGRAPHIES



India / Asia · EU · US · UK / Ireland · Africa · APAC · Latin America

ROLE LEVELS



FIVE CAPACITIES EXPLORED THROUGHOUT

Every question in the study was designed to surface one or more of five core capacities that form the backbone of the MX Responsible Leadership Framework. These are not competencies in the conventional HR sense; instead they are navigational qualities, the inner instruments leaders use to find their way when the external signals are contradictory or absent.

01	Awareness	Noticing early signals before they become crises
02	Clarity	Cutting through noise and staying steady under pressure
03	Connection	Relating to and considering people, teams and communities
04	Ethical Judgment	Using power in service of trust and shared values
05	Discernment	Choosing wisely between competing priorities or paths

External Pressure.

Internal Erosion.

Structural Absence.

SECTION 03

THE THREE-LAYER GAP MODEL

The original report identified five distinct gaps. On closer reading of the full qualitative dataset, a more precise architecture emerges. The five gaps are interdependent phenomena that constitute three types of structural failure operating at different levels simultaneously. Understanding the layering is what makes the findings actionable rather than merely descriptive.

LAYER 01 — EXTERNAL PRESSURE

Institutional incentives — quarterly targets, competitor pace, shareholder expectations — consistently reward speed over depth. Rather than a failure of individual leaders, this is a designed outcome of the systems they operate within. Speed is the water; responsible leadership must swim against it every day.

LAYER 02 — INTERNAL EROSION

The primary navigational instrument leaders use is inner clarity, and it is being systematically degraded by the conditions created in Layer 01. 52% of respondents cite mental clarity as their main internal signal. The same leaders report that emotional overwhelm, conflicting priorities and organisational noise are making that clarity progressively inaccessible. The compass exists; the conditions for reading it do not.

LAYER 03 — STRUCTURAL ABSENCE

The practices that restore and sustain the capacities described in Layer 02 — meditation, movement, nature, journaling, community — are cultivated almost entirely outside the organisations these leaders lead. The institutional support for responsible leadership practice is effectively zero. Wisdom exists; structure does not.



WHY THE LAYERING MATTERS FOR AI LEADERS SPECIFICALLY

In AI-era organisations, the three layers interact with particular intensity.

- Layer 01: Pressure is amplified by competitive dynamics that reward shipping over stewardship.
- Layer 02: Erosion is accelerated because AI expands the scope of decisions without expanding the human bandwidth to consider them.
- Layer 03: Absence is most acute in tech cultures that treat inner practice as personal rather than professional.

A leader cannot govern an AI system responsibly if the conditions for responsible judgment have been systematically removed.

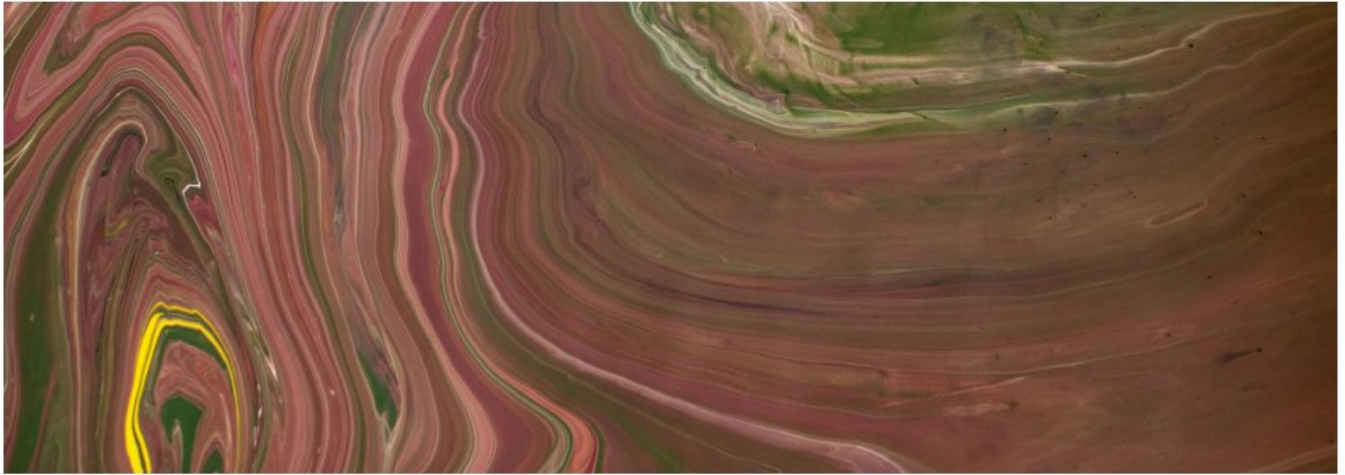


Wisdom
exists.

*Structure
does not.*

THE FIVE GAPS IN DETAIL

Within the three-layer model, the data reveals five specific, named gaps. These are presented not as abstract findings but as the actual lived tensions our respondents described — with the full interpretive weight of the qualitative material restored



Speed is
winning the
war against
connection.

KEY FIGURES

63%

chose "speed over impact" as their top AI-era challenge

57%

cite pressure for speed as their biggest obstacle to responsible decisions

52%

report connection and relational impact as hardest to sustain

WHAT HAS BECOME HARDER WITH AI?

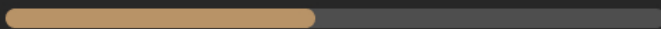
Choosing speed over impact 63%



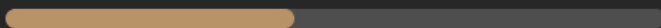
Connection & relational impact 52%



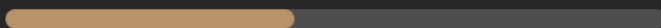
Ethical judgment beyond compliance 48%



Self-awareness & inner values 44%



Accountability & ownership 35%



When asked what has become harder with AI in their work, leaders pointed overwhelmingly to the human dimensions of leadership rather than the technical ones. The pattern is unmistakeable and the mechanism is clear: AI accelerates the tempo of work and the first casualty is human connection.

This is not simply about leaders moving faster. It is about institutional incentive structures that treat speed as virtue. Quarterly targets, competitive pressure, investor timelines — these create an environment in which choosing connection over pace is experienced not just as inefficient but as professionally risky. Leaders have the values, though they lack the permission structures and organisational cover to act on them.

The data on AI-specific challenges reinforces this: 48% cite ethical judgment beyond compliance as harder, 44% cite self-awareness and inner values, 35% cite accountability and ownership. In every case, the casualty is a human-centred capacity rather than a technical one.

Leaders
value
ethics, and
institutions
must catch
up.

KEY FIGURES

52%

name conflicting priorities as their biggest challenge

57%

name pressure for speed as their biggest obstacle

100%

link ethical values to long-term trust

Romano's formulation — the one-year comfort test — is more than a personal heuristic. It is a structural proposal: organisations that build regular ethical retrospectives into their decision cycles create the conditions for this kind of judgment. Those that do not leave leaders navigating by instinct alone, against institutional headwinds. Leaders are not asking for more rules. They are asking for the conditions to exercise judgment

Every respondent in this study connects ethical values to long-term trust. Not most — all. Yet the same leaders report that short-term institutional pressures consistently override the ethical judgments they would otherwise make. This is the central contradiction of responsible leadership in the AI era: the values are present and articulate; the structures that enable acting on them are absent.





The balance: long-term vision first — ethical values are the obvious foundation of that — need-to-stay-afloat second, but both important. Which decision today will I be proud of — or at least comfortable with — in one year?

— JENNY ROMANO, CO-FOUNDER AND CEO,
THE NEWSROOM (AI AND ML SECTOR)

The data on what leaders believe 'responsibility' is made of is equally instructive. Connection (87%), ethical leadership (83%), clarity (78%) and accountability (74%) all rank above compliance (39%). Leaders are asking for the conditions to exercise judgment.

GAP 03

Inner clarity
is the
compass —
but noise
drowns it out.

KEY FIGURES

PERCENTAGE OF LEADERS WHO

name mental clarity as their primary internal signal	52%
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are guided by ethical discomfort	22%
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rely on rules or governance frameworks as their primary guide	0%
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PRIMARY INTERNAL SIGNAL IN HIGH-PRESSURE MOMENTS

Mental clarity	52%
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Ethical discomfort	22%
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Gut instinct	13%
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Emotional cues	9%
----------------	----



Physical signals	4%
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More than half of respondents identify mental clarity as their primary navigational instrument in high-pressure moments — ahead of ethical frameworks, hierarchical guidance, emotional cues or physical signals. Zero respondents cite rules or governance frameworks as their primary guide.

This is not a governance matter in the abstract. The people responsible for the most consequential decisions in AI-era organisations are making those decisions using an internal instrument that their institutions provide no systematic support for maintaining. The organisational infrastructure for responsible leadership is, in this most critical respect, effectively absent.

The same leaders who report clarity as their compass also report that emotional overwhelm, conflicting priorities and lack of support are systematically degrading their access to it. The instrument is present; the conditions for reading it are not. This is an institutional design failure rather than a personal failure.

“

I look at it at 7 levels — emotional, physical, spiritual, mental, financial, digital, relational — and they obviously intersect. Being of service is central for me.

— VJERA ORBANIC, CO-FOUNDER, THE COACHING BODY /
ETHICAL INTELLIGENCE, UK

Orbanic's seven-dimensional framework is not unusual among this cohort. The grounding practices described by respondents are rich, embodied and sophisticated: meditation, nature, yoga, journaling, sea swimming, seasonal rituals, herbalism, poetry, cooking. These wisdom traditions sit far from wellness trends — ancient technologies for maintaining the clarity these leaders depend on. None of them is structurally supported within the organisations they lead

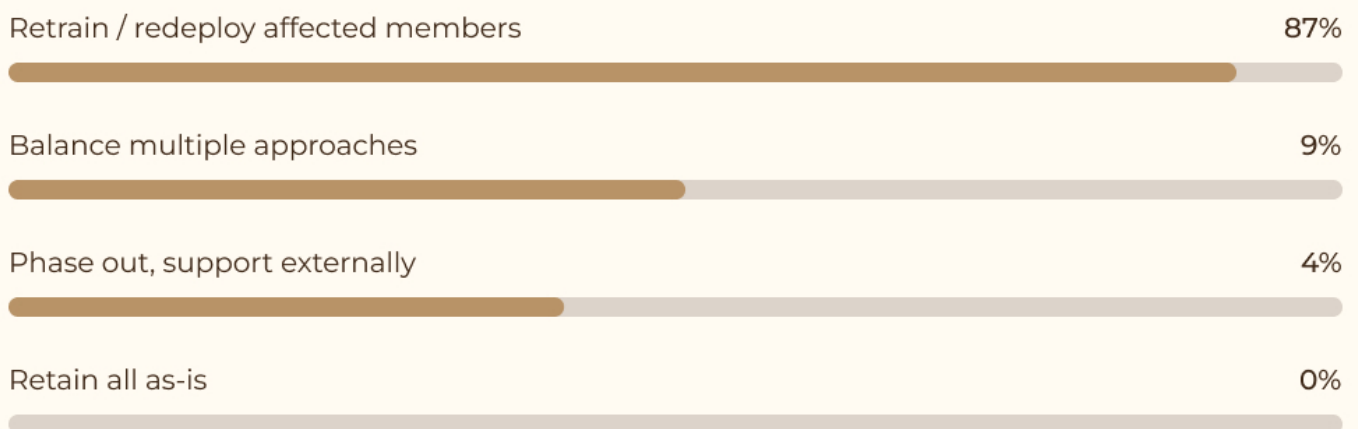
GAP 04

Leaders choose people,
and systems need to
make room for that.

KEY FIGURES

87%	would retrain or redeploy rather than eliminate roles
0%	would simply eliminate roles without support
9%	would balance multiple approaches by circumstance

AI REDUNDANCY SCENARIO — IF 2 OF 5 TEAM MEMBERS BECAME REDUNDANT DUE TO AI



We presented leaders with a concrete scenario: two of five team members become redundant due to AI. 87% said they would retrain or redeploy instead of eliminating roles. Zero respondents said they would simply cut the roles. This is a striking, near-unanimous statement of values. It sits in direct tension with the speed and efficiency pressures these leaders report everywhere else in the data.

The gap lies between values and the organisational conditions required to act on them. Retraining takes time and budget. Redeployment requires organisational flexibility and management commitment. Both require the kind of long-horizon thinking that quarterly incentive structures actively discourage.

“

Understanding that tools that can automate certain processes do not replace years of experience and our need for human-to-human contact. If organisations do not spend the time and effort to train juniors into seniors, soon we will have no seniors to hire.

— DAVID BERGENDAHL, SENIOR GENERATIVE AI STRATEGIST, AWS

Bergendahl's observation points to a second-order consequence that organisations systematically underweight: the institutional memory and relational infrastructure that AI cannot replicate. Eliminating roles for short-term efficiency creates a long-term capability deficit that compounds over time. Leaders see this. The incentive structures they operate within do not price it.

Wisdom
exists and
organisations
need to start
supporting it.

When asked how they stay centred and make better decisions, our respondents described practices of remarkable depth and consistency: daily meditation, morning poetry, weekly sea swimming, seasonal spiritual rituals, deep community conversation, cooking as grounding, journaling before major decisions, extended time in nature. More than anecdotal, these represent a coherent, cross-cultural body of practice for maintaining the clarity, presence and ethical attunement that responsible leadership requires.

Almost none of these practices are acknowledged, let alone supported, within the organisations these leaders lead. The irony is precise: the very capacities that make leaders most effective in conditions of complexity and ethical ambiguity are cultivated entirely outside the systems that most need them.

Grounding practices most frequently cited

Meditation and breathwork

Nature, walking and outdoor immersion

Yoga and physical movement

Reading — including poetry and philosophy

Journaling and reflective writing

Deep community conversation

Sea swimming and cold water

Cooking and food as ritual

Time with family and close friends

Creative practice — pottery, music, writing

Leaders who sustain rich grounding practices report higher clarity and confidence in high-pressure ethical decisions. Leaders who do not — or who cannot, due to pace and overload — report greater susceptibility to the speed-over-values compromise. This reflects what organisations lose when they treat inner practice as a private matter.

THREE ADDITIONS FOR AI LEADERS

The findings above apply across sectors. The three observations in this section address the specific conditions facing leaders who are building, deploying or governing AI systems, where the stakes of the responsible leadership gap are highest and the structural pressures most intense.

THE DECISION-SPEED TAXONOMY

AI leaders are not facing one speed problem. They are facing at least four distinct speed pressures simultaneously, each creating a different kind of ethical risk.



PRODUCT ITERATION SPEED

Weekly or daily release cycles compress the time for ethical review of new features, model updates and system changes. The gap between what can be shipped and what has been responsibly evaluated widens with every sprint. The responsible response is to embed ethical review into sprint processes as a standing item integrated into the workflow.

COMPETITIVE ANNOUNCEMENT SPEED

The arms-race dynamic of AI announcements, where being second is perceived as existential, creates pressure to launch before safety and ethical review are complete. This is the speed pressure most visible to boards and investors. The responsible response is board-level clarity on what the organisation will not do regardless of competitive pressure, establishing a published floor as a commitment rather than an aspiration.

MODEL TRAINING SPEED

The pace at which models are retrained on new data outstrips organisations' capacity to audit data quality, bias and downstream impact. Responsible judgment is displaced from the training loop rather than embedded in it. The responsible response is to establish data governance protocols with named human oversight before training begins and well prior to deployment.

REGULATORY RESPONSE SPEED

Governance and compliance frameworks are written annually or less frequently. AI systems iterate in weeks. The gap between what is technically possible and what is ethically governed is not a failure of regulation. It is a structural consequence of the speed differential. The responsible response is anticipatory ethics that runs ahead of compliance and remains ahead of regulatory frameworks.

The practical implication is that responsible leadership in AI requires a differentiated response to speed, rather than relying on a single intervention. Naming which speed type is operating is the first act of responsible leadership under pressure.

“

**LEADERSHIP IN THE
AGE OF AI
ORCHESTRATION
EVOLVES FROM
COMMAND AND
CONTROL TO SYSTEM
DESIGN AND
SENSEMAKING:
LEADERS MOVE FROM
MAKING DECISIONS
TO ARCHITECTING
HOW DECISIONS
HAPPEN.**

— JULIANA PROSERPIO, FOUNDER / CHIEF DESIGNER, ECHOS

RESPONSIBLE BY DESIGN

The MX framework has always framed responsible leadership as a mindset practice, centred on the cultivation of inner capacities. For AI leaders, this is necessary though not sufficient. The most consequential leadership decisions in an AI organisation are made upstream, embedded in product scope, dataset selection, model architecture and evaluation criteria. Responsible leadership must therefore also operate as a design practice.

01 · ETHICAL SCOPING AT PROJECT OUTSET

Before a model is trained or a product feature is built, responsible design asks: what populations are affected, what data will be used, and what is the floor of acceptable outcomes? This is not a compliance review — it is a values conversation that must happen before technical decisions foreclose it.

03 · VALUES-EMBEDDED EVALUATION CRITERIA

What a model is optimised for encodes organisational values more durably than any mission statement. Leaders who govern AI responsibly are present in the conversation about metrics and outcomes alike. The choice of what to measure is a leadership decision, shaped by strategy and governance and guided beyond technical implementation alone.

Proserpio's formulation — from making decisions to architecting how decisions happen — is the clearest articulation in our dataset of what responsible-by-design means in practice. It requires leaders to ask not only 'is this the right decision?' but 'does our system make it structurally possible to make the right decision at every point where this matters?'

02 · HUMAN OVERSIGHT BY DESIGN

Responsible systems are not those that minimise human involvement but those that preserve meaningful human judgment at the points where it most matters. This requires intentional architecture, not assumption. Default to human-in-the-loop at high-stakes decision points; document explicitly where you have chosen not to.

04 · DIVERSE TEAM DESIGN

As David Bergendahl and Vjera Orbanic both note, diverse teams and deliberate upskilling are not HR functions in the AI era. They are responsible design decisions that determine the range of perspectives embedded in what gets built and therefore in what harms are visible before they scale.

THE COST OF THE GAP

The responsible leadership gap has real costs: measurable, organisational costs that accumulate over time and surface as avoidable failures. Our qualitative data contains the evidence.

One respondent shut down a company to protect people and reflects in retrospect that a different balance of values-in-action might have given the business more runway while still protecting its team. Another describes executing a team reduction with right values but wrong execution and the lasting damage that followed. A third speaks of accumulated ethical compromise in the face of speed pressure that only became visible in aggregate. These are the predictable outcomes of the gap operating over time rather than edge cases.

TRUST EROSION

Leaders who consistently choose speed over connection produce cultures where psychological safety declines, candour diminishes and the signals needed to navigate responsibly stop flowing upward. By the time the deficit is visible, it is expensive to reverse. The compounding dynamic is particularly acute in AI organisations, where the speed pressure is structurally highest and the relational tax therefore greatest.

TALENT ATTRITION

The leaders in this study are active and intentional about their values. Those operating in institutions that provide no structural support for responsible practice eventually leave, taking with them exactly the ethical grounding and relational intelligence the institution most needs in the AI era. Responsible leadership is a retention factor and extends beyond a compliance function.

REGULATORY AND REPUTATIONAL EXPOSURE

AI systems built without embedded ethics create regulatory liability that compounds with scale. The responsible-by-design gap does not remain theoretical — it manifests in audits, investigations and public failures that are far more expensive to manage than the ethical review would have been. Every week of speed gained by skipping ethical scoping creates months of remediation risk downstream.

PRODUCT HARM

Decisions made under speed pressure without the clarity, discernment and connection that responsible leadership requires produce products that harm the people they purport to serve. This is the ultimate cost — and the least reversible. The people affected by AI systems built without ethical leadership are real, and the consequences for them do not disappear when the quarter closes.



The inverse is equally true. Leaders who sustain strong grounding practices, operate in institutions that create structural space for responsible judgment, and treat ethics as a design function rather than a compliance function report greater confidence, clearer decisions and more durable teams. The gap has a cost. Closing it has a return.

WHAT THE DATA TELLS US

Responsible leadership is not a knowledge problem: leaders know what it looks like. They believe in it deeply. Our data shows they would choose people over process, ethics over expedience, and long-term vision over short-term gain, when given the structural conditions to do so.

WHAT THE DATA TELLS US

THE CENTRAL FINDING

The gap lies between values and practice. Between what leaders believe in private and what institutions make possible in public. Between the inner compass and the outer culture. Between the wisdom leaders carry and the structures that should support it but do not.

For AI leaders specifically, the gap has a third dimension: between values and practice, and between individual judgment and systemic architecture. The most important responsible leadership decisions are made in the code, the data, the product brief, the evaluation criteria. Responsible leadership in the AI era requires governing the system and governing oneself through design and oversight.

FIVE GAPS. ONE PRACTICE NEED.

Gap 01	Speed is winning: Connection is being sacrificed for pace.
Gap 02	Values vs action: Ethics is aspirational, not operational.
Gap 03	Clarity under siege: Inner compass exists; access to it doesn't.
Gap 04	People vs systems: Leaders choose people; organisations choose efficiency.
Gap 05	Wisdom without structure: Rich practices exist; organisations don't support them.

CONCLUSION

PRACTITIONER IMPLICATIONS

The following observations are grounded directly in the data and actionable by any leader or organisation, independent of any programme or resource.

01 · BUILD ONE STRUCTURED PAUSE POINT PER DECISION CYCLE

Leaders who create regular moments of ethical reflection — even brief — report meaningfully higher clarity and confidence. This does not require retreats or frameworks. It requires a protected 20 minutes before major decisions where the question is simply: what are we not seeing, and who is not in this room?

02 · TREAT GROUNDING PRACTICE AS PROFESSIONAL INFRASTRUCTURE

The practices that sustain clarity — movement, reflection, nature, community — are not perks. They are the maintenance system for the primary instrument of responsible leadership. Organisations that acknowledge this structurally — through protected time, flexible scheduling, peer practice communities — invest in the quality of every decision their leaders make.

03 · MAKE THE SPEED TYPE EXPLICIT

Not all speed pressure is the same. Naming which type of speed is operating — product iteration, competitive announcement, regulatory lag — changes how leaders can respond. What is urgent about each is different. The responsible response to each is different. Making the distinction is the first act of responsible leadership under speed pressure.

04 · EMBED ETHICAL CONVERSATION IN PRODUCT PROCESS

For AI leaders, the most impactful intervention is placing values conversations at the point in the process where they can still change outcomes — in scoping, in data selection, in metric design — not only in review. This is not a legal or compliance function. It is a leadership function.

05 · MEASURE THE GAP, NOT JUST THE VALUES

Many organisations measure whether leaders hold responsible values. Few measure the distance between those values and daily practice. That distance — the coherence gap — is the operative variable. Closing it requires knowing how wide it is.

THE MX RESPONSE: MINDSET OVER METRICS

THE MX RESPONSE: MINDSET OVER METRICS

Responsible Mindset

Cultivating the inner capacities — clarity, discernment, presence, ethical judgment — that enable leaders to navigate the AI era with integrity.

Responsible Tech

Translating values into design, governance and deployment decisions that keep human dignity and wellbeing at the centre.

Responsible Futures

Expanding leadership horizons beyond quarterly goals to consider systemic impact, intergenerational consequence, and regenerative possibility.

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Leadership becomes more resilient when theory and metrics are integrated with lived practice, keeping humanity at the core.

— MODULE XERO RESPONSIBLE LEADERSHIP FRAMEWORK, 2026

Section 07

WHAT YOU CAN DO NEXT

This report is the first instalment of MX's 500-Leader Research Study. The pilot findings are clear; the 500-leader study will establish the evidence base needed to translate these patterns into systemic change. Three ways to contribute and engage

WHAT YOU CAN DO NEXT

01

JOIN THE 500-LEADER RESEARCH STUDY

Help us build the most comprehensive evidence base on responsible leadership in the AI era. The questionnaire takes 8 minutes. Your responses will directly inform our White Paper, HBR article and Playbook — shaping the frameworks that guide the next generation of leaders.

Take the questionnaire: [Responsible Leadership in the AI Era survey](#)

02

ATTEND THE RESPONSIBLE LEADERSHIP RETREAT

A 4-day immersive experience for senior AI and tech leaders. June–July 2026, Asia. Facilitated by Module Xero, The Newsroom and Echos. Covering Responsible Mindset, Responsible Tech and Responsible Futures. Limited to 35 participants. Early-bird pricing available.

Apply for a place: retreat.modulexero.com

03

JOIN THE LEADER COMMUNITY

Connect with leaders who refuse to choose between performance and humanity. A curated network of leaders of today and tomorrow — research-backed, action-oriented, IDG-aligned. Powered by the Radical Human podcast and the MX thought leadership ecosystem.

Join the community: [Responsible Leadership Initiative in the age of AI](#)

ABOUT MODULE XERO

Module Xero (MX) is a learning and development company dedicated to bringing connection to the heart of leadership. Founded by Sheena Bhalla — former Google executive, IDG Ambassador, yoga teacher, and daughter of a nurse who modelled service leadership every day — MX works with senior leaders and organisations to develop responsible leadership as a mindset, not a compliance function.

MX's Responsible Leadership Initiative is a research-driven initiative to build the world's first evidence-based, embodied framework for responsible leadership in the age of AI, delivered through a connected suite of assets: research study, Responsible Leadership Retreat and actionable Playbook.



SHEENA BHALLA **FOUNDER, MODULE XERO**

Former Google Executive · IDG Ambassador · Yoga Teacher · Theatre Artist · 26+ roles across 5 countries. On a mission to make responsible leadership systematic, measurable and human.

MODULEXERO.COM



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